



cricket, depth and resilience at the bottom could shape the destiny of a World Cup.

Australia's blueprint

The early signs of this lower-lineup revolution can be traced to Australia, a team long recognised for its batting depth.

"They bat so deep and we know the talent they've got," said Sophie Devine after New Zealand's loss to the Aussies in the opener. "You just can't take your foot off the throat because they bat all the way to 11."

The warning became a reality against Pakistan.

Australia, teetering at 76 for seven, saw No. 10 Alana King rewrite the script with an unbeaten 51, her highest-ever ODI score coming under intense pressure. Together with Beth Mooney, she stitched a record 106-run ninth-wicket partnership.

The tournament statistics underlined the trend. The four teams with the most productive lower orders reached the semifinals: India and South Africa led the way,

followed by England (214) and Australia (173).

Depth that delivers

While Australia set the early tone, the tournament's defining showcase of lower-order batting came in the clash between India and South Africa, with the spotlight firmly on Richa Ghosh and Nadine de Klerk.

Richa, batting at No. 8, made an immediate impression with a highest score of 94, keeping her team competitive with stability and aggression when the top faltered.

De Klerk, walking in at No. 8, responded in style, demonstrating why she has become South Africa's go-to finisher. In seven innings, she scored 208 runs, striking at 131.64 and averaging 52.

"We've always known Nadine's very talented. It seems like this year, her batting is really clicking," said Marizanne Kapp after South Africa's comprehensive win over Pakistan in Colombo. De Klerk joined forces with the veteran to hammer 52 runs off 20 balls while racing to an individual score of 41 off just 16.

Depth defined: Richa Ghosh (facing page, left) and Nadine de Klerk embodied the rise of the lower order at the 2025 Women's World Cup, turning crisis into opportunity and redefining the finisher's role. EMMANUAL YOGINI &

K. R. DEEPAK

Statistical leaps at No. 8

The contrast between the finishers and those who merely survived was evident throughout the tournament. England's Charlie Dean, another regular at No. 8, scored 124 runs in six innings, but her strike rate of 67.39 and boundary percentage of 5.97 lagged far behind De Klerk's and Richa's.

Meanwhile, Richa was strategically shuffled around the order, held back to unleash her natural aggression in the closing overs. Even though she batted at No. 8 only twice during the tournament, she outscored Dean and trailed only De Klerk, compiling 129 runs at a strike rate of 132.98.

Naturally, the No. 8 position emerged as the pivotal spot for